

ANGEL ACTION · AIRWAY

Recovery Position

The recovery position protects the airway of an unconscious person who is breathing normally by keeping them on their side so the tongue cannot block the throat and fluids can drain.

When to use the recovery position

Use the recovery position for any person who is **unconscious but breathing normally**, including after a seizure, fainting episode, head injury, intoxication or overdose.

Do **not** use the recovery position if you suspect a spinal injury **unless** the person is vomiting or you cannot keep their airway clear — airway always comes first.

How to do it (adult / child over 1 year)

1. Kneel beside the person.
2. Extend the arm closest to you above their head.
3. Bring the far arm across the chest, palm against the near cheek.
4. Bend the far knee up so the foot is flat on the ground.
5. Pull on the bent knee and roll the person towards you onto their side.
6. Adjust the upper leg so the hip and knee are bent at right angles.
7. Tilt the head back slightly to keep the airway open. Check breathing every minute.

Infant (under 1 year)

Hold the baby face-down along your forearm with the head slightly lower than the body, supporting the head and neck with your hand. This lets fluids drain while keeping the airway clear.

See also

The recovery position is part of the **Airway** step of **DRSABCD**.

Adapted from Australian First Aid 5th Edition. Get the full guide and live CPR metronome at firstaidangel.org.